million people can be engaged. "This is assuming the number of job-seekers remain static. Every year, nearly 10 million youths are being added to the workforce. There is no way government can cater to this demand," says Satyananda Mishra, former secretary, Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT). That's why you see those unreal images on the ground.

The Mess

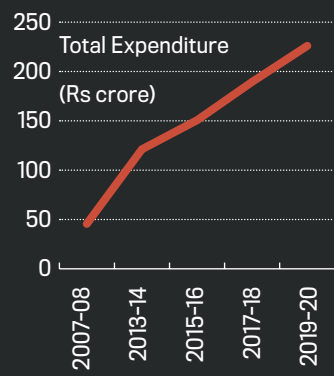
Consider this: in December 2021, the announcement of 15 openings at the Gwalior district court—for posts like peon, gardener, cleaner and driver—saw 11,000-odd applications. Required qualification for most of the jobs: Class X pass. But among those 11,000 were graduates, post-graduates, even MBAs. This is not an aberration. In 2018, some 3,700 Ph.D. holders, 50,000 graduates and 28,000 post-graduates applied for 62 openings for the post of messenger in the Uttar Pradesh police. Required minimum eligibility: Class V. You see two levels of mismatch: quantity, i.e. the sheer volumes, and quality. The youth don't care. All they want is the job. That's what played out in Bihar on the eve of this year's Republic Day.

The immediate trigger? In 2019, the Indian Railways had conducted an exam for 35,281 non-technical positions. It attracted 12.5 million applications—354 applications per post. The results for the first stage were declared on January 15. The anger was about a change in the number of qualifying exams and confusion over the process to determine the minimum cut-offs. The Railway Recruitment Board (RRB) later clarified the allegations were misplaced. But from the days of the Vyapam scam, 'due process' has been a farce in the public eye. To begin with, the public sector has a rather limited scope to create employment. Successive regimes have exacerbated that by not filling up existing vacancies, and not doing anything to allay increasing public mistrust in the process. That's what leads to all those signs of unprecedented desperation—Bihar's job riots included. "It's a reflection of the distress in the economy," says Anupam, president, Yuva Halla Bol, a nationwide movement that seeks to mobilise youth against unemployment in an organised manner. It's not as if political parties do not recognise the distress. Often, they utilise it as a poll plank. If Prime Minister Narendra

WHAT INDIA SPENDS ON SALARIES

In terms of share of GDP, the expenses on salaries by the states have nearly doubled in the past 15 years, but central government expenses have remained the same

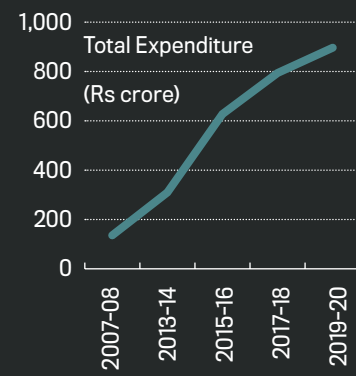
CENTRAL GOVERNMENT'S EXPENSES ON PAY AND ALLOWANCES



	2007-08	2013-14	2015-16	2017-18	2019-20
Share of GDP (%)	1	1.08	1.09	1.11	1.6

Source: Ministry of Finance; Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation

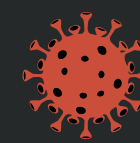
STATE GOVERNMENTS' EXPENSES ON PAY AND ALLOWANCES



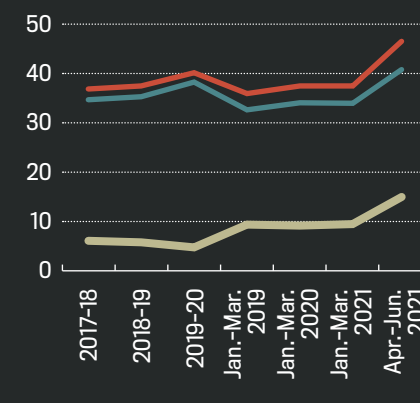
	2007-08	2013-14	2015-16	2017-18	2019-20
Share of GDP (%)	2.8	2.8	3.7	4	4

Source: State Finances: A Study of Budgets of 2021-22 by the Reserve Bank of India

THE PANDEMIC



The unemployment rate has doubled after the pandemic while the labour force participation rate–population either working or actively looking for work–has dropped. The massive cut in private sector jobs has put pressure on government sector.



Sources: Survey by Labour Bureau; Periodic Labour Force Survey; Economic Survey, 2021